

AS Business 9609 - Exam Technique

A step-by-step guide to laying out 2, 3, 5, 8 and 12 mark answers so you pick up every available mark. For the Oct/Nov 2026 exam (syllabus 2026-2028). Each mark tariff shows: what it tests, the structure, WHERE the K and APP go, the key words to write, an "ask yourself" checklist, and THREE tagged worked examples.

PART A - THE FOUNDATIONS

1. The four skills (Assessment Objectives)

Every mark you earn comes from one of these four skills. Learn the tags - they are used on every worked example below.

- [K] Knowledge (AO1): define terms and state relevant theory correctly.
- [App] Application (AO2): use the SPECIFIC business/context in the question (its name, product, market, numbers, situation).
- [An] Analysis (AO3): build cause-and-effect chains - push each point to its final effect on the business.
- [Ev] Evaluation (AO4): make and justify a judgement. Needed ONLY on 12 (and higher) mark questions.

2. Match your effort to the marks

The tariff tells you how much to write and which skills are tested:

- 2 marks - Define / State - [K] only. One or two sentences. ~3 min.
- 3 marks - Define / State / Identify - [K] (+ small [App]). Definition plus a short example. ~4 min.
- 5 marks - Explain - [K] + [App] + a little [An]. Point, define, apply, develop ONE step. ~6 min.
- 8 marks - Analyse - [K] + [App] + [An]. Two developed chains, NO judgement. ~10 min.
- 12 marks - Evaluate / Discuss / Recommend / To what extent - [K] + [App] + [An] + [Ev]. Two chains PLUS a weighed judgement. ~15 min.

Rough timing rule: about 1 to 1.5 minutes per mark. Never leave a 12-marker unfinished to over-write a 3-marker.

3. Command words - what each one is really asking

- State / Identify / Give / What is meant by - just name it or define it. Knowledge only.
- Define - give a precise meaning using the exact key words.
- Explain - give a reason AND develop it one step, applied to the business.
- Analyse - build full cause-and-effect chains. No opinion, no judgement.
- Evaluate / Discuss / Assess / To what extent / Recommend - argue BOTH sides in chains, then give a justified judgement.

4. WHERE to put the K and the APP (the golden order)

For any developed answer (5, 8 or 12 marks) write each paragraph in this fixed order. This guarantees you hit each skill in turn:

- STEP 1 - [K] first: state your point and DEFINE the key term. Example opener: "One benefit is X, which means [definition]."

- STEP 2 - [App] next: immediately tie it to THIS business. Example opener: "In the case of [business name], which [context from the case]..."
- STEP 3 - [An] next: develop the chain. Use: "this means... because... which leads to... therefore..." until you reach profit, cost, cash flow or competitiveness.
- STEP 4 - [Ev] last (12 marks only): stand back and judge - which side wins, why, and what it depends on.

Memory hook: DEFINE it (K) -> LOCATE it in the business (APP) -> DEVELOP it (AN) -> DECIDE (EV).

PART B - LAYOUT AND EXAMPLES BY MARK TARIFF

5. The 2-mark answer - "Define / State"

Tests: [K] only. A precise definition made of TWO parts, OR two clearly stated items (1 mark each). One or two sentences.

Structure

- Define: "[Term] is [part 1] [K] which [part 2] [K]."
- State two: "Two [items] are [item 1] [K] and [item 2] [K]."

Key words to write

- "is defined as...", "refers to...", "is when...", "Two examples are... and..."

Ask yourself

- Have I given TWO precise elements (or two items)?
- Have I used the exact syllabus term?
- Have I resisted wasting time on examples or explanation (no marks here)?

Worked examples

(a) "Define opportunity cost" [2]: Opportunity cost is the benefit of the next best alternative [K] that is given up when a choice is made [K].

(b) "State two factors of production" [2]: Two factors of production are land [K] and labour [K].

(c) "Define market segmentation" [2]: Market segmentation is dividing a market into distinct groups of customers [K] who share similar characteristics or needs [K].

6. The 3-mark answer - "Define / State (+ example)"

Tests: [K] (+ a small [App]). A precise definition (2 marks) PLUS a short example or expansion (1 mark).

Structure

- "[Term] is [clear precise definition] [K][K]. For example, [quick example] [App]."

Key words to write

- "...is the difference between...", "...is the amount by which...", "For example...", "such as..."

Ask yourself

- Is my definition precise and made of two parts?
- Have I added ONE relevant example or piece of extra detail?
- Have I still kept it short (no chains, no consequences)?

Worked examples

- (a) "Define added value" [3]: Added value is the difference between the selling price of a product and the cost of the bought-in materials used to make it [K][K]. For example, a coffee shop buying beans for \$0.30 and selling a coffee for \$3.00 adds \$2.70 of value [App].
- (b) "Define productivity" [3]: Productivity is a measure of the output produced per unit of input, such as per worker, in a period [K][K]. For example, output per employee = total output / number of employees [App].
- (c) "Define limited liability" [3]: Limited liability means the owners are only responsible for business debts up to the amount they invested [K][K], so a shareholder who buys \$500 of shares can lose at most \$500 [App].

7. The 5-mark answer - "Explain"

Tests: [K] + [App] + one step of [An]. Point -> define [K] -> apply to the business [App] -> develop ONE consequence [An].

Structure

- "One [benefit/reason] is [point], which means [define] [K]. For [business/context] this [apply] [App], so [one consequence] [An]."
- If it says "Explain two...", write two shorter versions (~2-3 marks each).

Key words to write

- "One reason is...", "which means...", "In the case of [business]...", "this means that...", "so...", "as a result..."

Ask yourself

- Have I clearly stated and DEFINED my point (K)?
- Have I linked it to THIS business, not businesses in general (App)?
- Have I developed at least one consequence (An)?
- Have I avoided writing a full evaluation (not needed)?

Worked examples

- (a) "Explain one benefit to a firm of low labour turnover" [5]: One benefit is a more experienced workforce, as low turnover means fewer staff leave so skills are retained [K]. For a manufacturer relying on skilled machine operators [App], this means higher quality and productivity [An] and lower recruitment and training costs [An].
- (b) "Explain one limitation of a business plan" [5]: One limitation is that a business plan relies on forecasts that may prove inaccurate, because it is based on assumptions about future sales and costs [K]. For a new bakery predicting demand it cannot yet know [App], if actual sales are far lower than forecast [An], the plan can give false confidence and lead to poor decisions, so the firm may run short of cash [An].
- (c) "Explain one reason a business holds inventory" [5]: One reason is to avoid stock-outs, since holding buffer inventory lets production and sales continue if demand rises or a delivery is late [K]. For a supermarket selling fast-moving food [App], this means shelves stay full [An], so it keeps customers and does not lose sales to rivals [An].

8. The 8-mark answer - "Analyse"

Tests: [K] + [App] + [An]. TWO points, each a full chain. NO intro, NO conclusion, NO judgement.

Structure (write this twice)

- "One [way/benefit/drawback] is [point] [K]. This means [define] [K]. For [business/context] this

[apply] [App]. As a result [effect 1] [An], which in turn [effect 2] [An], meaning [final effect on profit/cost/competitiveness] [An]."

Key words to write (analysis connectives)

- "this means...", "because...", "which leads to...", "as a result...", "this in turn...", "therefore...", "ultimately..."

Ask yourself

- Do I have TWO separate, different points?
- Is each point defined (K) and applied to THIS business (App)?
- Have I pushed each chain to a FINAL effect (profit, cost, cash, competitiveness) - not stopped at the first consequence?
- Have I correctly written NO judgement (none needed at 8 marks)?

Worked example 1 - "Analyse two ways business enterprise can help the development of a country" [8]

Point 1 - Job creation: One way is by creating employment [K]. Enterprise involves entrepreneurs setting up businesses that combine the factors of production and must hire workers [K]. In a developing country where unemployment is high [App], these new businesses employ local people [App]. As a result more households earn an income [An], so they spend more locally [An], raising demand for other firms and creating further jobs through a multiplier effect [An], gradually raising living standards [An].

Point 2 - Higher output and tax revenue: A second way is by increasing national output (GDP) and tax revenue [K]. As enterprises produce and sell, they add value and generate profits and wages [K]. In a developing economy [App] this raises GDP and means firms and workers pay more tax [App]. As a result the government receives more revenue [An], which it can invest in infrastructure, education and healthcare [An], improving productivity and driving further long-term development [An].

Worked example 2 - "Analyse two benefits to a clothing retailer of market segmentation" [8]

Point 1 - Better-matched products: One benefit is that segmentation lets the retailer target groups with similar needs [K]. In the case of a fashion chain splitting its market by age and income [App], it can design ranges that fit each group precisely [An], so customers are more satisfied and buy more [An], raising sales revenue [An].

Point 2 - Less wasted marketing spend: A second benefit is more efficient promotion, because messages are aimed only at the relevant segment [K]. For the retailer advertising a teen range on social media rather than on TV [App], less money is spent reaching people who will not buy [An], so the cost per sale falls [An] and profit margins improve [An].

Worked example 3 - "Analyse two ways a business could improve its cash flow" [8]

Point 1 - Chase trade receivables faster: One way is to shorten the credit period given to customers [K], since cash owed is collected sooner [K]. For a wholesaler waiting 60 days for payment [App], cutting this to 30 days brings cash in earlier [An], so it has enough cash to pay wages and suppliers on time [An], reducing the risk of insolvency [An].

Point 2 - Negotiate longer credit from suppliers: A second way is to delay paying trade payables [K], keeping cash in the business for longer [K]. For the same wholesaler [App], paying suppliers after 60 rather than 30 days improves the net cash position each month [An], so it can fund day-to-day costs without an expensive overdraft [An], lowering interest costs [An].

Reminder: an 8-mark "Analyse" question does NOT need a judgement.

9. The 12-mark answer - "Evaluate / Discuss / Recommend"

Tests: [K] + [App] + [An] + [Ev]. Argument FOR as a full chain, argument AGAINST (or an alternative) as

a full chain, then the JUDGEMENT - where the top marks are.

Structure

- (Optional) one-line intro that defines the key term.
- Argument 1 (FOR / benefit) - a full applied chain (like an 8-marker).
- Argument 2 (AGAINST / drawback / alternative) - another full applied chain.
- Judgement [Ev]: a clear decision; WHY one side outweighs the other (rank them); an "it depends on..." named factor; a short-term vs long-term point; and a link back to the specific business.

Key words to write (judgement starters)

- "Overall, the most important factor is X because..."
- "This depends largely on [named factor]: if [condition] then [choice A], but if [condition] then [choice B]..."
- "In the short term [effect], but in the long term [effect], so on balance..."
- "Therefore I recommend X, provided that [condition]."

Ask yourself

- Have I argued BOTH sides, each as a developed chain (K+App+An)?
- Have I made a CLEAR decision (not "it could go either way")?
- Have I said WHY one side outweighs the other (ranked them)?
- Have I added an "it depends on..." factor and a short vs long term point?
- Have I linked the judgement back to THIS specific business?
- Did I spend about a third of my time on the judgement?

Worked example 1 - "Intrapreneurship is the most important factor for the success of a computer games business." Evaluate. [12]

Intro: Intrapreneurship means employees using entrepreneurial skills to innovate within an existing business [K].

FOR: It is important because success in games depends on constant innovation [App]. Intrapreneurs create new ideas and features from within [K/App], so the firm keeps launching fresh titles [An], stays ahead of fast-moving rivals [An] and earns repeat sales and higher long-term profit [An].

AGAINST: However, finance and marketing may matter more [K]. Even a great game needs large sums for long development [App]; without finance it may never launch [An], so it fails despite good ideas [An]. Equally, in a crowded market, without marketing customers will not know it exists [App], meaning low sales even for an excellent game [An].

JUDGEMENT: Overall, intrapreneurship is a major factor but not automatically THE most important [Ev]. It is necessary but not sufficient - innovation only creates success if funded and marketed [Ev]. It depends on the situation [Ev]: for a new studio, securing finance is most critical in the short term, whereas for an established studio intrapreneurship is key to staying competitive long term [Ev]. So the statement is only partly true [Ev].

Worked example 2 - "A private limited company should become a public limited company (Plc)." Evaluate. [12]

FOR: Floating raises large amounts of share capital because shares can be sold to the public [K/App]. For a firm wanting to expand nationally [App], this funds new factories and outlets [An], so it can grow faster and gain economies of scale [An], lowering unit costs and raising profit [An].

AGAINST: However, selling shares to the public dilutes ownership [K]. For the founding family [App], this risks losing control and even a hostile takeover [An]; it also brings pressure for short-term dividends and costly disclosure of accounts [An], which can harm long-term decisions [An].

JUDGEMENT: Whether to float depends mainly on how much finance is needed and how much control the owners will accept [Ev]. If the expansion is large and cannot be funded by loans or retained profit, becoming a Plc is justified [Ev]; but if the owners value control and the sum is modest, a bank loan is better [Ev]. On balance, for most growing firms the loss of control outweighs the benefit unless the capital required is very large [Ev].

Worked example 3 - "For a new innovative product, penetration pricing is better than skimming." Evaluate. [12]

FOR penetration: A low launch price attracts price-sensitive buyers quickly [K]. For a new streaming service entering a crowded market [App], this wins market share fast [An], builds a large subscriber base and brand awareness [An], and enables economies of scale [An].

AGAINST (skimming may be better): A high initial price earns a large margin from customers who want the product first [K]. For a genuinely innovative tech gadget with few rivals [App], skimming recovers high development costs quickly [An] and creates a premium image [An], though it risks slow early sales [An].

JUDGEMENT: The best method depends on the level of competition and how unique the product is [Ev]. Where rivals are many and the product is easy to copy, penetration is better to grab share [Ev]; where the product is truly unique with high development costs, skimming is better in the short term before rivals enter [Ev]. So penetration is not always better - it suits crowded markets, not genuinely new innovations [Ev].

PART C - QUICK REFERENCE

10. Analysis connective bank (use these to build chains)

- this means... / this results in... / because... / which leads to...
- as a result... / this in turn... / consequently... / therefore...
- ultimately... / meaning that... (end on profit, cost, cash or competitiveness).

11. Evaluation / judgement bank (12-mark answers)

- "The most important factor is... because..."
- "This depends on... (e.g. the size of the firm, its objectives, the state of the economy, the level of competition)."
- "In the short term... whereas in the long term..."
- "On balance... provided that..."

12. One-look revision card

2 marks: definition (2 parts) OR two items. [K] yes. No example needed.

3 marks: definition + example. [K] yes, [App] small. No chains.

5 marks: 1 point. [K] + [App] + one [An] step. No intro/conclusion.

8 marks: 2 points. [K] + [App] + 2-3 [An] steps each. No judgement.

12 marks: 2 points + JUDGEMENT. [K] + [App] + [An] + [Ev] essential.

13. The three biggest mark-losers to avoid

- Not linking to the business in the question - you lose ALL Application marks.
- Listing many points without developing them - you lose Analysis marks. Fewer, deeper chains score higher.

- Writing no judgement on a 12-marker - you cap your mark at roughly half.

Golden rule: DEFINE it (K) -> LOCATE it in the business (APP) -> DEVELOP it (AN) -> DECIDE (EV).
Apply every point to the specific business and justify every judgement to reach the top mark bands.